



KIDD'S TECHNICAL SERVICES

Mount Hope, West Virginia

September 10, 2026

To: Thurmond City Council

CC: Superintendent, New River Gorge National Park and Preserve

Re: Submission of Thurmond Historic District Economic Outlook and Preservation Investment Case

Enclosed is the report, "Thurmond Historic District Economic Outlook and Preservation Investment Case," prepared by Kidd's Technical Services. The report presents an independent economic analysis of the Thurmond Historic District and recommends a preservation-centered, time-bounded transaction-readiness demonstration before additional irreversible removal of potentially viable historic assets occurs.

The analysis finds that Thurmond's economic opportunity begins with documented existing demand rather than speculative growth. With 19,233 recorded visits in 2024 and nearly two million annual visits park-wide, the district already has a measurable customer base. At current visitation, even restrained improvements in local spending capture correspond to multi-million-dollar ten-year direct-spending capacity if appropriate places, services, and experiences are available. The report also shows that a substantial share of the currently quantified maintenance burden is concentrated in houses that the National Park Service itself rated as having medium potential for historic leasing.

The economic question is therefore not simply what the historic structures cost to carry. It is whether selected assets can be repositioned through long-term leasing, historic tax credits, state tourism incentives, preservation grants, and private or nonprofit operating models so that they begin producing value for the district while reducing long-term federal burden. The report recommends that this question be tested with current property-level costs, lease terms, visitor data, and financing interest before viable options are permanently lost.

This report is advisory. Kidd's Technical Services has no decision-making authority regarding National Park Service property or Town of Thurmond policy. Its recommendations are based on the economic, preservation, tourism, and public records cited in the report and are offered for independent consideration by the responsible public entities. I stand behind the analysis to the best of my knowledge based on those records and official sources.

Respectfully submitted,

Carrie Kidd

Owner, Kidd's Technical Services



THURMOND HISTORIC DISTRICT

Economic Outlook and Preservation Investment Case

A place-based analysis of visitor demand, adaptive reuse finance, and federal asset economics

A measurable visitor market already exists. The economic question is how much of that market Thurmond can convert into productive use, recurring revenue, and preserved historic assets.

Prepared by Carrie Kidd

Kidd's Technical Services

September 2026

Prepared for the Town of Thurmond, the National Park Service, and community, preservation, and financing stakeholders

Executive Economic Finding

Thurmond is not starting from zero. It sits inside one of West Virginia's strongest tourism growth stories, is already a named destination within New River Gorge National Park and Preserve, and has documented visitor traffic. The most important economic finding is that the district does not have to rely on speculative visitor growth to justify action: at current documented visitation, even restrained improvements in local spending capture create multi-million-dollar ten-year direct-spending capacity if the district can provide reasons and places for visitors to spend. At the same time, the Park Service has identified a group of historic houses as costly maintenance liabilities even though its own 2024 review rated seven of those houses as having medium potential for historic leasing. The central opportunity is to test whether selected federal historic assets can be converted from vacant liabilities into externally capitalized, lease-supported, visitor-serving properties.

**2025 park visitation: 1,958,440 recreation visits | 2024 Thurmond visitation: 19,233 |
2024 NPS gateway spending: \$95.5 million**

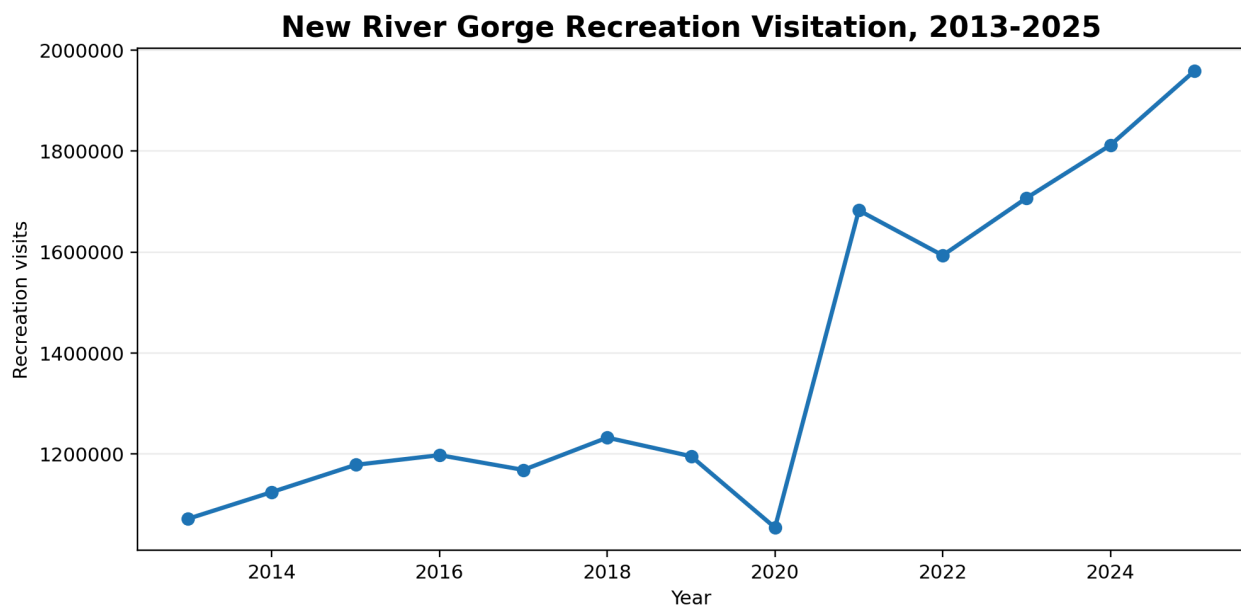


Figure 1. Official NPS IRMA recreation visitation. Visitation increased 82.7% from 2013 to 2025. Source: NPS IRMA [1].

The market signal is strong enough to justify transaction testing. A rural redevelopment project usually must first prove that customers will come. Thurmond already receives visitors because NPS and regional tourism systems direct them there. The economic challenge is to increase the share of time and spending that those visitors retain in Thurmond, while using preservation finance and leasing to reduce the amount of rehabilitation capital that must be carried by NPS or by a small local operator.

The Existing Visitor Economy Is Already Large

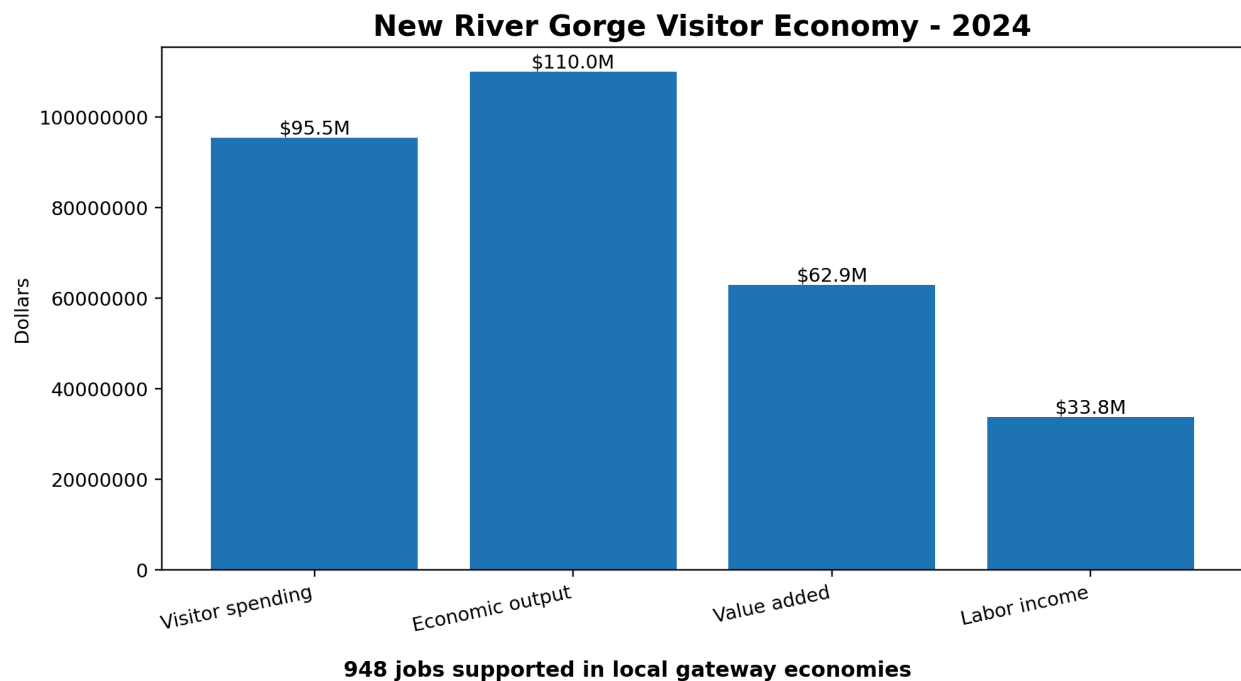


Figure 2. NPS-estimated 2024 visitor spending effects for New River Gorge National Park and Preserve. Source: NPS Visitor Spending Effects [3].

NPS estimates that 1,811,937 visitors in 2024 spent \$95.5 million in local gateway economies, supporting 948 jobs, \$33.8 million in labor income, \$62.9 million in value added, and \$110 million in economic output. [3] The corresponding park-wide gateway-spending benchmark is approximately \$52.71 per recreation visit. That benchmark is not a measurement of current spending in Thurmond; it is a scale indicator for the broader market in which Thurmond is already participating.

At 19,233 documented Thurmond visits, every additional \$10 of average local visitor spending equals \$192,330 in annual direct sales.

The Immediate Opportunity Is Conversion of Existing Traffic

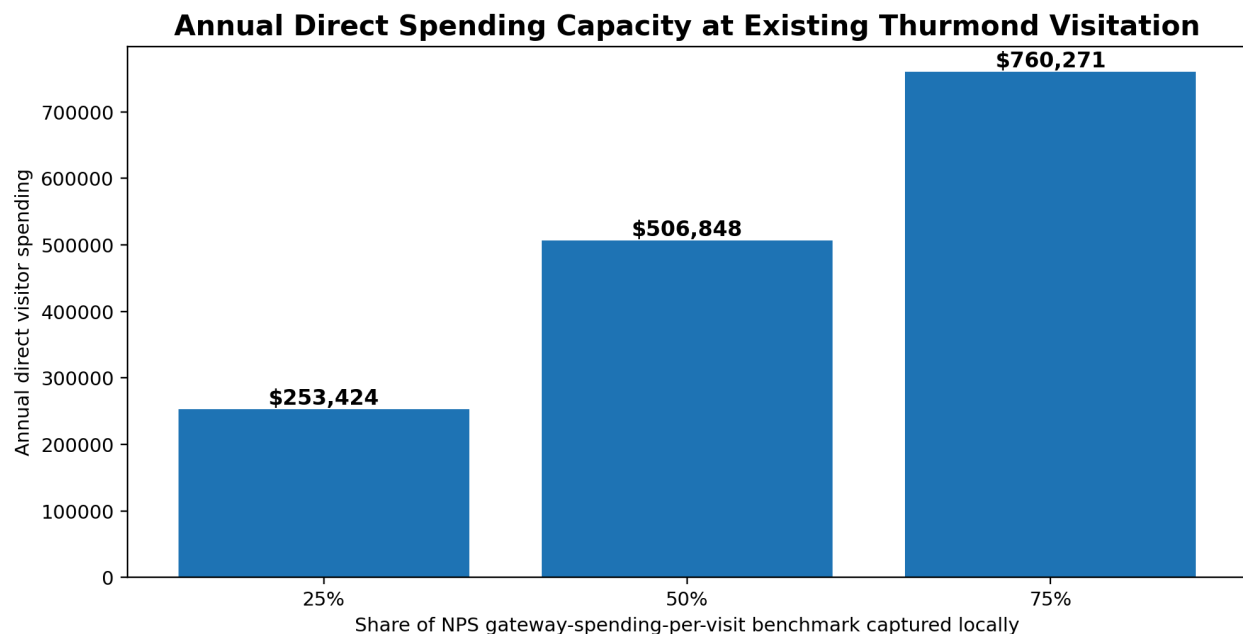


Figure 3. Direct-spending sensitivity using 19,233 documented Thurmond visits and fractions of the 2024 NPS gateway-spending benchmark. These are planning scenarios, not measured current sales. Sources: Fayette County tourism report [2]; NPS Visitor Spending Effects [3].

At existing visitation, a local spending level equal to 25% of the regional benchmark corresponds to approximately \$253,424 in annual direct visitor commerce. At 50%, the figure is \$506,848; at 75%, \$760,271. None of these calculations assumes that Thurmond first attracts more visitors. They isolate the value of improving the experience and providing appropriate opportunities to buy food, services, interpretation, lodging, tours, local products, transportation, events, or other visitor-serving offerings.

The economic proposition is therefore not dependent on a high-growth tourism forecast. It can be tested against the people who are already arriving. A stronger destination may eventually increase visitation, but the first measure of success should be better conversion of existing demand into dwell time, customer satisfaction, and local sales.

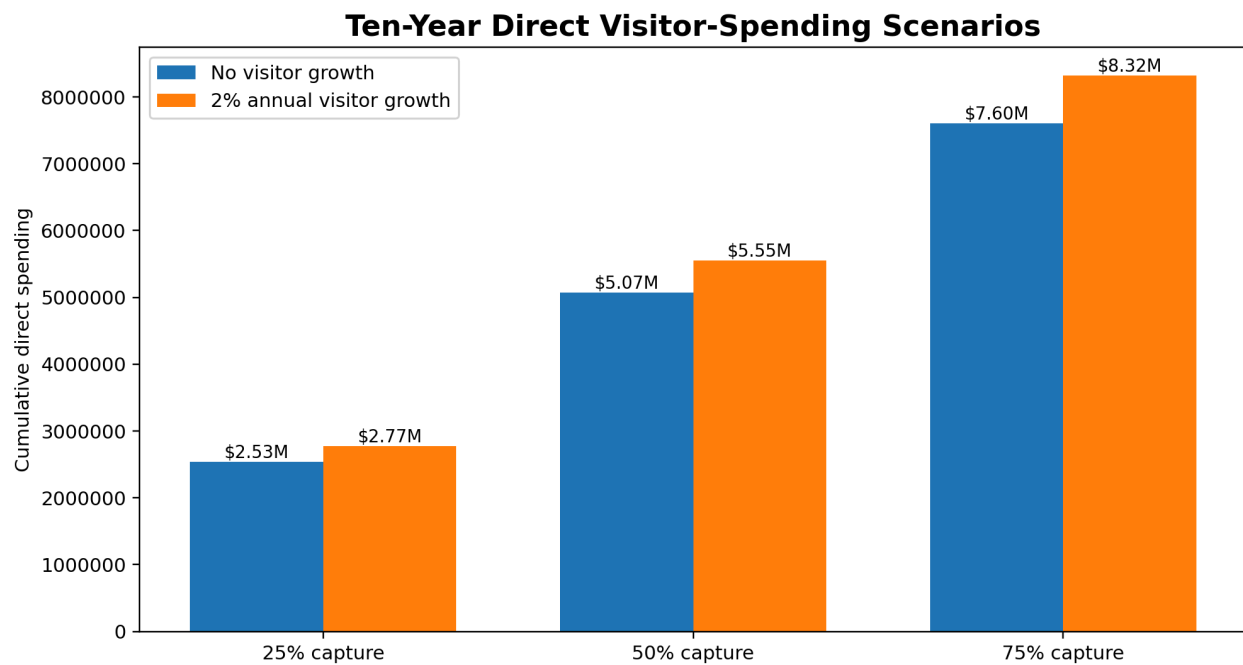


Figure 4. Ten-year direct visitor-spending scenarios at the current Thurmond visitor base, with either no visitor growth or a restrained 2% annual growth assumption. The growth case is a scenario, not a prediction. Sources and calculations: [1]-[3].

Central planning case: 50% capture with 2% annual visitor growth corresponds to approximately \$5.55 million in ten-year direct visitor spending.

Historic Status Can Be a Financing Asset

The cost side of the analysis changes materially when historic rehabilitation is treated as a capital-structure problem rather than as a single-agency maintenance expense. For a qualifying income-producing certified rehabilitation, the federal Historic Rehabilitation Tax Credit equals 20% of qualified rehabilitation expenditures. West Virginia provides a separate 25% historic rehabilitated buildings investment credit, and the state allows unused credit to be transferred, sold, or assigned after approval. [11][12]

Nominal Historic Tax-Credit Leverage per \$1 Million of Qualified Rehabilitation

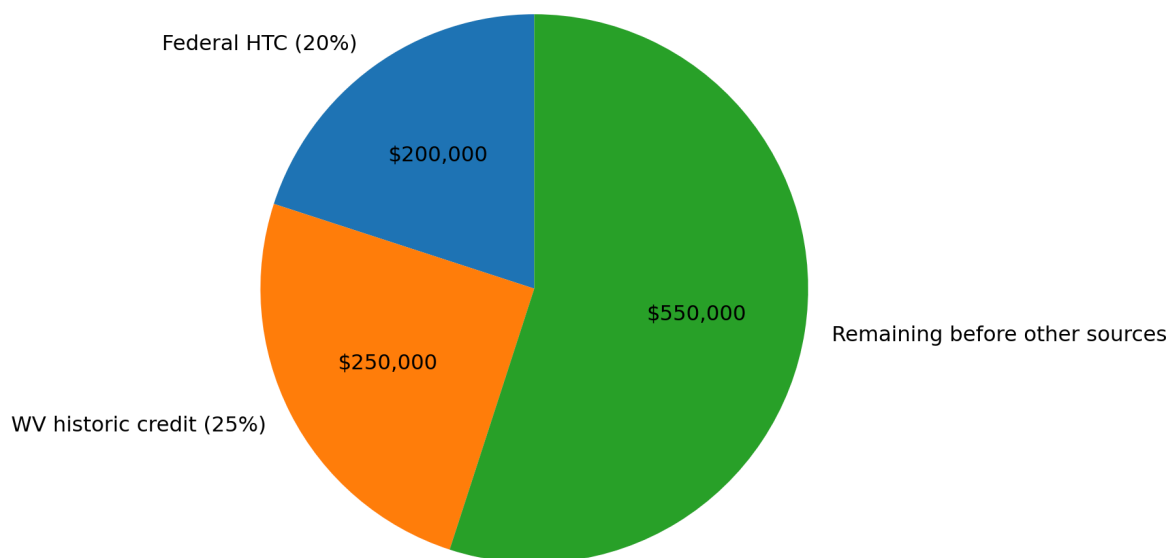


Figure 5. Statutory face-value illustration on \$1 million of qualified rehabilitation expenditures. Credit monetization, tax basis, timing, lease structure, and transaction costs can change actual project proceeds. Sources: NPS [11] and WV Tax Division [12].

At face value, the two historic-credit programs represent \$450,000 per \$1 million of qualified rehabilitation expenditures. The relevant implication for NPS is not that government receives a 45% reimbursement. It is that a properly structured long-term lease can permit historic status to attract tax-advantaged private capital to the rehabilitation of a federal asset. NPS has already used long-term leasing and historic tax credits in other national park units. [19][20]

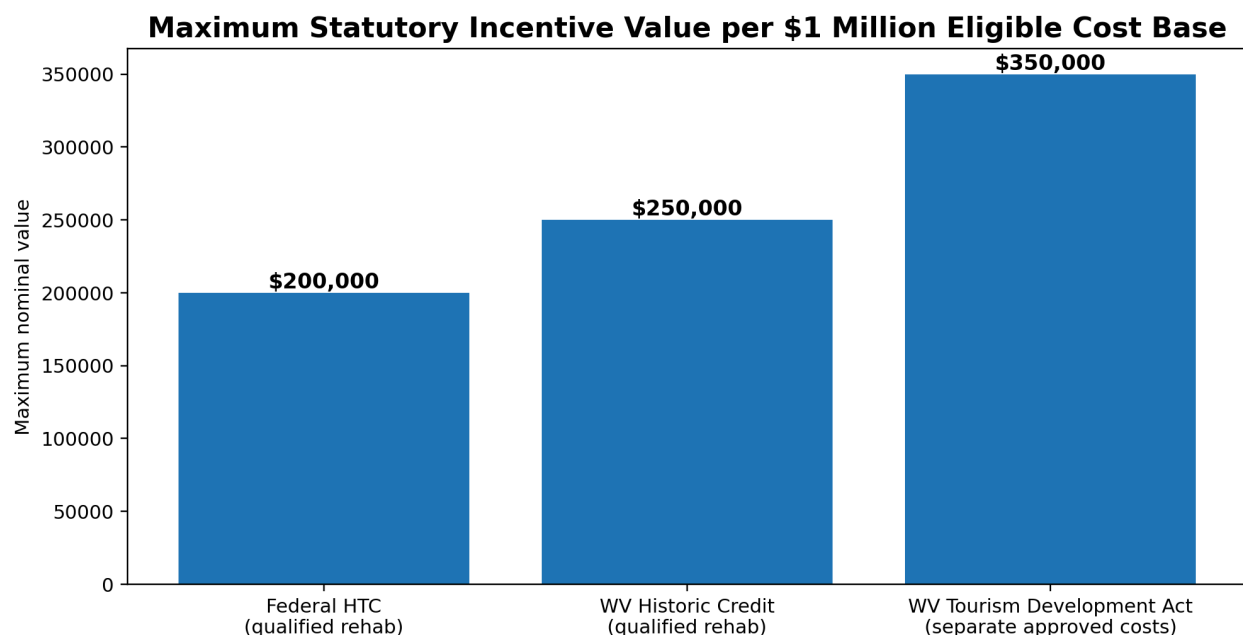


Figure 6. Maximum statutory incentive values on separate \$1 million eligible cost bases. The two West Virginia programs cannot simply be added to the same state cost dollar. Tourism Development Act costs must be separately eligible and approved. Sources: [11]-[13].

West Virginia adds a second, unusually relevant economic-development mechanism. The Tourism Development Act allows an approved tourism project a sales-tax credit of up to 25% of approved costs, increasing to 35% for qualifying projects involving National Register properties, contributing structures in National Register districts, or projects on or within five miles of state or federal recreational land. The statute expressly recognizes leasehold interests of at least ten years and can include project improvements such as water, sewer, sewage treatment, gas, electricity, communications, and utility extensions. [13] This creates a potential way to separate eligible historic rehabilitation costs from eligible visitor-serving infrastructure costs rather than forcing one source of capital to carry every project need.

NPS Has Already Identified the Highest-Value Conversion Target

The attached June 2024 NPS structure review sheets allow a more precise economic reading of the Thurmond maintenance problem. Ten Thurmond structures have exact DM&R figures in those sheets totaling \$2,001,187. Seven houses were each rated by NPS as having medium potential for historic leasing. Those seven alone account for \$1,907,277 of quantified DM&R. [4]

95.3% of Known Quantified Thurmond DM&R Is in Houses NPS Rated for Leasing

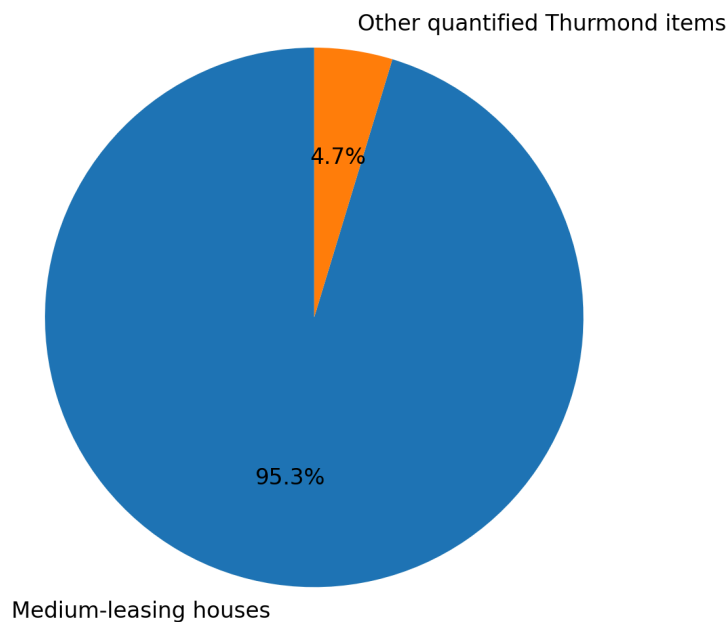


Figure 7. Concentration of exact DM&R amounts available in the 2024 Thurmond structure review sheets. Seven houses rated medium for historic leasing account for 95.3% of the known quantified total. Source: NPS 2024 EA, Appendix B [4].

This is a major economic finding. The quantified maintenance burden is not concentrated primarily in assets that NPS itself judged to have no possible productive pathway. It is concentrated in the class of buildings for which NPS repeatedly identified historic leasing as a medium-potential reuse. That does not establish financial feasibility, but it identifies where a focused transaction-readiness effort can produce the most information per dollar of planning effort.

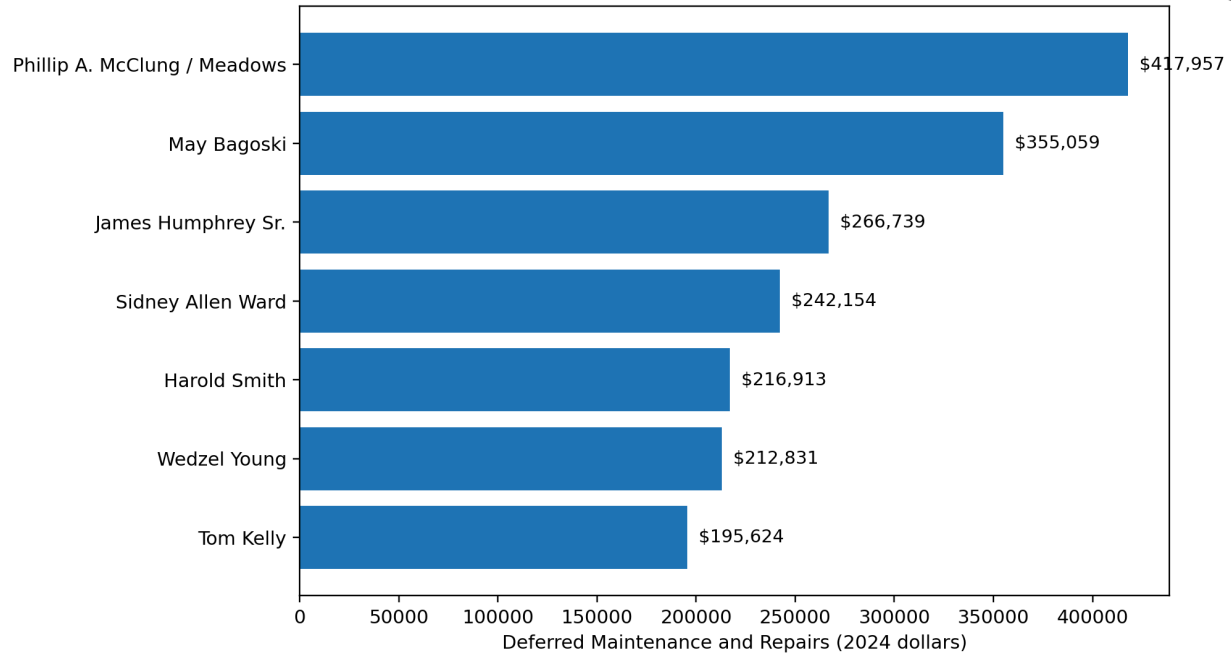
NPS-Quantified DM&R on Houses Rated Medium for Historic Leasing

Figure 8. Exact 2024 DM&R figures for the seven Thurmond houses that NPS rated medium for historic leasing. DM&R is an NPS facilities metric, not a current contractor rehabilitation estimate. Source: NPS 2024 EA, Appendix B [4].

Structure	2024 NPS DM&R	Historic leasing rating	NPS reuse note
Phillip A. McClung / Meadows	\$417,957	Medium	Substantial rehabilitation / utility work noted by NPS
May Bagoski	\$355,059	Medium	Substantial rehabilitation / utility work noted by NPS
James Humphrey Sr.	\$266,739	Medium	Substantial rehabilitation / utility work noted by NPS
Sidney Allen Ward	\$242,154	Medium	Substantial rehabilitation / utility work noted by NPS
Harold Smith	\$216,913	Medium	Substantial rehabilitation / utility work noted by NPS
Wedzel Young	\$212,831	Medium	Substantial rehabilitation / utility work noted by NPS
Tom Kelly	\$195,624	Medium	Substantial rehabilitation / utility work noted by NPS

The Investment Case Is Consistent With Earlier NPS Planning

The economic reuse concept is not foreign to New River Gorge planning. In the 2011 Record of Decision for the General Management Plan, NPS selected Alternative 5. The ROD states that the selected alternative would rehabilitate and lease the greatest number of historic structures, better protect their integrity, and generate an income stream for ongoing maintenance. It also states that partnerships with gateway communities and expanded NPS participation in regional economic-development efforts would foster links between the park and surrounding communities. [6]

The 2023 pre-NEPA document likewise describes active planning to stabilize and rehabilitate key historic Thurmond structures, upgrade water and wastewater systems, improve Commercial Row drainage, and preserve selected structures so that future rehabilitation and use remain possible. [5] The 2024 EA then documents the institutional constraint that many other structures had received minimal or no maintenance and that the park lacked sufficient funding and staffing to maintain all of them. [4][5]

The economic opportunity identified here therefore does not require a reversal of the park mission. The relevant question is whether the park can use a tool already present in its own planning history - historic leasing - in combination with capital sources that are not available through an ordinary federal maintenance budget.

The proposal is not "NPS rehabilitates every building." It is "NPS tests which assets can attract non-NPS capital under a preservation-compatible lease."

A changed institutional condition since the 2024 EA

The 2024 EA dismissed leasing in part because New River Gorge did not then have an existing leasing program, staffing, funding, or administrative capacity to manage one. [4] The current New River Gorge website, updated August 31, 2026, now publishes a park-specific leasing framework and contact. It states that NPS can lease historic and nonhistoric properties, that fair-market rent is required, and that leasing revenue can fund historic preservation projects, capital improvements, and maintenance backlog. [8]

The 2025 FONSI also created a direct property-specific opening: NPS chose the modified reuse alternative and stated that it may consider leasing the Tom Kelly House in Thurmond if a viable proposal is received. The FONSI authorizes implementation of demolition for other selected structures, so the opportunity is time-sensitive, but the final decision itself recognizes leasing as an acceptable path for at least one Thurmond building. [7]

Federal Fiscal Outlook: From Carrying Cost to Leveraged Asset

A preservation-and-leasing transaction should be evaluated from the federal balance sheet as well as from the community balance sheet. Under current law, NPS leases require fair-market-value rent, but the Secretary may adjust rent to account for lessee expenditures for preservation, maintenance, restoration, improvement, and repair. Lease receipts are deposited into a dedicated Treasury account that can be used for infrastructure, refurbishment, repair, and direct maintenance of leased buildings and associated property. [10]

NPS's FY2025 New River Gorge infrastructure fact sheet adds a second important fiscal point: commercial leases remain in the park property inventory but do not contribute to the reported Deferred Maintenance and Repairs total. [9] NPS financial staff should confirm how pre-existing DM&R is treated as a specific property enters a commercial lease, but the published accounting rule establishes that a successful lease can materially change how the asset sits on the park's ongoing maintenance ledger.

Current vacant-asset condition	Lease-supported condition
NPS retains ownership and carries a deteriorating vacant asset	NPS retains ownership while a lessee occupies and maintains the asset under enforceable lease terms
DM&R and recurring inspection/security burden remain on the park	Commercial lease can shift defined maintenance and capital responsibilities away from park operations
Rehabilitation competes for limited federal capital	Historic tax-credit equity, state incentives, grants, bank/CDFI debt, and lessee equity can enter the project
No operating rent from the vacant building	Fair-market lease can create recurring NPS revenue
Visitor value is primarily interpretive/exterior	Productive use can add a reason to dwell, purchase, return, and experience adjacent resources

NPS-side success should be measured as outside capital leveraged + federal asset preserved + maintenance responsibility shifted/shared + lease revenue + visitor value, less direct federal capital and administration.

A quantified illustration using the NPS DM&R scale

The seven medium-leasing houses carry \$1,907,277 in quantified 2024 DM&R. DM&R is not a rehabilitation budget, and not every rehabilitation dollar would be a qualified rehabilitation expenditure. Still, using that amount only as a scale test shows why tax-credit underwriting matters. If a future certified project happened to generate \$1,907,277 of qualified rehabilitation expenditures, the federal 20% credit would have a face value of approximately \$381,455, the West Virginia 25% credit approximately \$476,819, and the combined nominal value approximately \$858,275. The remaining amount before grants, investor pricing, debt, equity, or lease concessions would be approximately \$1,049,002. This is a financing sensitivity, not a claim about construction cost.

The West Virginia Tourism Development Act Fits the District Economics

The Tourism Development Act is unusually aligned with the economic conditions present in Thurmond. State law evaluates whether a project will attract at least 25% of visitors from outside West Virginia, exceed \$1 million in approved costs, operate at least 100 days per year, create employment, address economic problems in its location, improve opportunities for other commercial businesses, diversify the local economy, and be economically and fiscally sound. [13] Those tests are not peripheral to the Thurmond case; they are essentially the questions this economic study is designed to answer.

For an illustrative \$1 million approved project qualifying for the maximum 35% credit, the maximum credit would be \$350,000. The statute normally allows the credit over ten years, producing an annual allowance of \$35,000. At West Virginia's 6% state sales-tax rate, \$35,000 corresponds to about \$583,333 in taxable annual sales. Divided by the documented 19,233 Thurmond visits, that is approximately \$30.33 of taxable sales per visitor. [13]

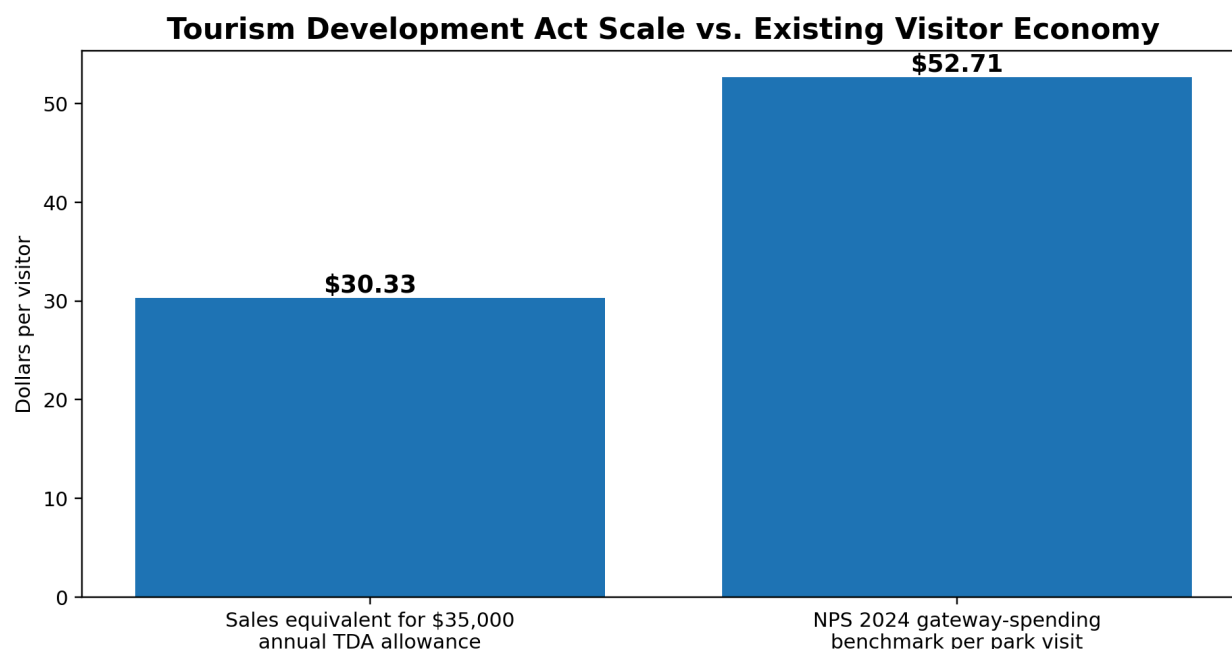


Figure 9. Scale comparison only. The \$30.33 figure is the taxable-sales equivalent needed to generate \$35,000 of state sales tax at 6%, before project-specific base-tax and approval rules. The \$52.71 figure is the 2024 NPS gateway-spending benchmark, not current Thurmond sales. Sources: [2][3][13].

The comparison is informative because \$30.33 equals about 57.5% of the NPS regional spending benchmark. It does not prove a \$1 million project will qualify or generate sufficient sales. It shows that the statutory scale is not obviously disconnected from the size of the existing visitor economy. A serious feasibility phase can test the remaining gap with real customer data and an operating concept.

The appropriate capital model is cost allocation, not double counting

A project should not assume that every incentive can be applied to the same dollar. Instead, predevelopment should sort costs into legally distinct buckets. Qualified historic rehabilitation expenditures should be evaluated for federal and state historic credits. Separate tourism infrastructure and visitor-development costs should be evaluated for Tourism Development Act treatment. Eligible preservation tasks can be submitted to competitive grant programs. Remaining costs can be assigned to bank/CDFI debt, investor equity, lessee equity, or NPS work where NPS determines a federal contribution is strategically justified. [11]-[14]

Preservation Capital Available to the Transaction

West Virginia SHPO State Development Grant

The FY27 State Development Grant is currently open with a September 30, 2026 deadline. It supports brick-and-mortar work including stabilization, rehabilitation, code compliance, accessibility, and work needed to place a historic property into appropriate modern use. The program requires a one-to-one match, at least half of the sponsor match must be cash, and only non-federal money may be used as cash match. Long-term lessees with written owner permission are among eligible applicants. [14]

For a Thurmond lease transaction, this is potentially important because it provides a real mechanism for a non-federal lessee or eligible partner to help fund preservation work. Project-specific eligibility, federal-property permission, timing, and match structure would need SHPO confirmation before any amount is included as committed capital.

Preservation Alliance of West Virginia

PAWV provides several forms of support that can reduce transaction friction and build local execution capacity. Its Historic Preservation MicroLoan Fund offers up to \$20,000 at 2% interest on a rolling basis and can support architecture, engineering, appraisals, tax-credit consulting, stabilization, and rehabilitation. [16] Preserve WV AmeriCorps is accepting 2026-27 site-sponsor applications; a full-time placement provides 1,700 service hours for a \$4,400 site cash match, and a half-time placement provides 900 hours for a \$2,200 site cash match. Eligible assignments include preservation technical assistance, heritage-tourism programming, volunteer management, property documentation, tours, and organizational/site planning. [17]

PAWV also has demonstrated subgrant capacity. Its 2022 Saving Historic Places round awarded \$488,008.53 across seven rural projects, including \$108,810 to the City of Hinton for the New River Grocery Building and \$102,808.15 for Wheby's Grocery Store in Princeton. [18] The currently published Frontier to Statehood round is not a base-case source for the buildings discussed here because it is limited to properties dating through 1871 and its 2026 deadline has passed. Accordingly, no PAWV grant amount is assumed in the numerical outlook. The organization is included because it has active financing/capacity programs and a demonstrated record of moving preservation capital in West Virginia.

Survey, feasibility, architecture, and project preparation

WV SHPO also administers Survey and Planning Grants that can support feasibility studies, Historic Structure Reports, plans/specifications, surveys, and preservation planning. The program is not currently accepting applications, so this report does not count it as available project cash; it should remain in the next-cycle predevelopment pipeline. [15]

Comparable Transactions Show That the Structure Is Real

NPS precedent: Bathhouse Row and Hale Bathhouse

Hot Springs National Park provides the most directly relevant federal precedent. After an unsuccessful effort to lease Bathhouse Row under a master lease, NPS shifted to building-by-building leasing. NPS performed selected lead and asbestos abatement to lower the entry cost for lessees. Private lessees then invested approximately \$2 million to \$4.5 million per bathhouse, with historic tax credits playing a significant role. Uses now include a boutique hotel, brewery and restaurant, and museum. NPS describes the result as preservation that supports small businesses and energizes the surrounding community. [19]

The Hale Bathhouse case is even more specific. A long-term NPS lease supported a certified rehabilitation with \$1,134,784 in qualified rehabilitation expenditures and an estimated \$226,956 federal historic tax credit. The building reopened as a boutique hotel, restaurant, and conference center and employed 40 full-time employees at the time of the NPS case study. [20]

West Virginia precedent: Tygart Hotel, Elkins

The Tygart Hotel demonstrates the West Virginia financing side. A nearly \$16 million redevelopment converted a historic downtown property into a boutique hotel and restaurant serving a tourism and outdoor-recreation market. The financing combined state and federal tax credits, grants, bank and CDFI loans, and New Markets Tax Credit equity. Davis Trust, Freedom Bank, and Pendleton Community Bank made Historic Tax Credit investments. The project was expected to create more than 55 permanent jobs; a later Opportunity Appalachia report states the hotel opened in 2024 with 57 permanent jobs and had become catalytic for more than \$30 million in anticipated follow-on investment across four additional projects. [21][22]

Precedent	Public/ownership structure	Private or outside capital evidence	Economic lesson for Thurmond
Bathhouse Row, Hot Springs NP	NPS historic assets under commercial leases	\$2M-\$4.5M lessee investment per reopened bathhouse; HTC support	NPS can sequence properties individually, lower selected entry costs, and let private users carry productive reuse
Hale Bathhouse	Long-term NPS lease	\$1.135M QRE; ~\$226,956 federal HTC	Federal ownership and a long lease can coexist with an income-producing HTC rehabilitation
Cavallo Point, Golden Gate NRA	60-year NPS lease	>\$100M total investment; bank loans, private equity, HTC equity, federal funds	Long lease can attract substantial external capital and ongoing maintenance responsibility
Tygart Hotel, Elkins WV	Historic private/community redevelopment	~\$16M stack with local-bank HTC investors, CDFIs, grants, credits	WV institutions already know how to assemble preservation capital around a tourism anchor

Recommended Thurmond Transaction-Readiness Demonstration

Kidd's Technical Services recommends that an initial demonstration be designed to answer an investment question, not to predetermine the fate of every building. A six-month transaction-readiness period could focus on any still-standing structures for which NPS has identified leasing potential or for which new information could materially change the reuse analysis. The Tom Kelly House is the clearest anchor because the 2025 FONSI explicitly preserves the possibility of a lease if NPS receives a viable proposal. [7]

For the transaction-readiness period to have economic meaning, Kidd's Technical Services recommends that NPS consider a time-bounded deferral of irreversible removal for screened Thurmond structures where legally and operationally practicable while life-safety controls remain in place. The purpose would be to produce a documented GO / NO-GO decision for each screened asset, not an open-ended postponement.

Phase 1 - Days 0-60: establish the true deal

- Confirm which candidate structures are still standing, their current condition, and the implementation schedule under the 2025 FONSI.
- Obtain or commission current structural, environmental, utility, access, code, and rehabilitation scopes for the anchor property and any parallel candidates.
- Separate NPS DM&R from actual occupancy rehabilitation cost and identify likely qualified rehabilitation expenditures.
- Confirm NPS appraisal approach, lease term, rehabilitation credits against rent, maintenance obligations, insurance, access rights, and RFP requirements.
- Meet with WV SHPO and PAWV on preservation scope, tax-credit process, immediate funding windows, and technical assistance.

Phase 2 - Days 61-120: test capital and customer demand

- Prepare a project-specific capital stack with federal HTC, WV historic credit, eligible grants, bank/CDFI debt, and lessee equity; separately test Tourism Development Act costs where appropriate.
- Seek nonbinding lender, tax-credit investor, CDFI, operator, and preservation-partner indications sufficient to determine whether a real financing path exists.
- Conduct a short visitor intercept study measuring origin, reason for visiting Thurmond, dwell time, current spending, unmet expectations, desired services, and willingness to purchase specific experiences or products.
- Develop at least one operating concept with realistic staffing, seasonality, pricing, sales, maintenance reserve, and lease assumptions.

Phase 3 - Days 121-180: make an evidence-based decision

- Produce a property-level feasibility model and district-level economic update.
- Identify the minimum public contribution, maximum outside-capital leverage, projected NPS rent, lessee obligations, and maintenance responsibilities.
- For a feasible property, prepare the materials necessary for NPS to determine whether and how to proceed through its required public leasing process.
- For properties that fail the test, document why: physical condition, access, utilities, insufficient demand, financing gap, or other controlling factor.

The demonstration succeeds even if some buildings fail underwriting. Its purpose is to replace assumption with transaction evidence before an irreversible asset decision is executed.

District-Scale Economic Outlook

The district outlook improves if the first lease transaction proves that three markets can function together: a visitor market, a real-estate/operating market, and a capital market. Once the first transaction produces actual sales, lease, construction, and customer data, subsequent properties no longer begin as unpriced experiments. They inherit a local comparable, an administrative pathway, known lenders and preservation professionals, utility lessons, operating data, and a documented visitor profile.

Local capture level	Annual direct spending at 19,233 visits	10-year: no visitor growth	10-year: 2% annual visitor growth
25% of regional benchmark	\$253,424	\$2,534,238	\$2,774,919
50% of regional benchmark	\$506,848	\$5,068,475	\$5,549,839
75% of regional benchmark	\$760,271	\$7,602,713	\$8,324,758

These scenarios are deliberately based on existing documented visitation rather than on an aggressive visitor-growth assumption. The 2% case is included only to show sensitivity. The important economic point is that even the no-growth cases produce multi-million-dollar ten-year direct-spending capacity if the district can provide reasons and places for visitors to spend.

How one viable lease can change the district

Pilot result	District-level economic consequence
Measured visitor sales and dwell time	Subsequent businesses can underwrite demand using Thurmond-specific data rather than regional anecdotes.
Executed NPS lease	Establishes a real local process for appraisal, preservation standards, maintenance allocation, insurance, access, and public solicitation.
Closed preservation financing	Creates a repeatable relationship with tax-credit counsel, banks, CDFIs, SHPO, PAWV, investors, and contractors.
Occupied historic building	Adds a destination node that increases the utility of nearby historic resources and can extend visitor dwell time.
Recurring NPS lease revenue	Creates a direct federal fiscal return that can support preservation and maintenance.
Successful public-private coordination	Reduces perceived execution risk for the next building and for complementary private investment nearby.

Central planning outlook

A reasonable central planning case for evaluation - not a promised outcome - is local spending equivalent to 50% of the 2024 NPS gateway-spending benchmark. At the documented 2024 Thurmond visitor count, that is approximately \$506,848 in annual direct visitor commerce. With no growth in visitation, the ten-year cumulative amount is about \$5.07 million. With a 2% annual visitor-growth scenario, it is about \$5.55 million. This is the size of the direct market that a cluster of operators could collectively compete to capture; it is not revenue assigned to a single building.

Preservation Investment Has Measured Economic Effects Beyond the Tenant

NPS and Rutgers University provide a national benchmark for the broader economic activity associated with federal Historic Tax Credit rehabilitation. For FY2024, \$6.8 billion in rehabilitation investment was associated with \$12.8 billion in economic output, \$6.6 billion in GDP, \$4.8 billion in income, \$1.8 billion in tax revenue, and approximately 116,000 jobs. [11] Normalized only for scale, that is approximately \$1.88 million in economic output, \$971,000 in GDP, \$706,000 in income, \$265,000 in tax revenue, and 17.1 job-years per \$1 million of rehabilitation investment at the national program level.

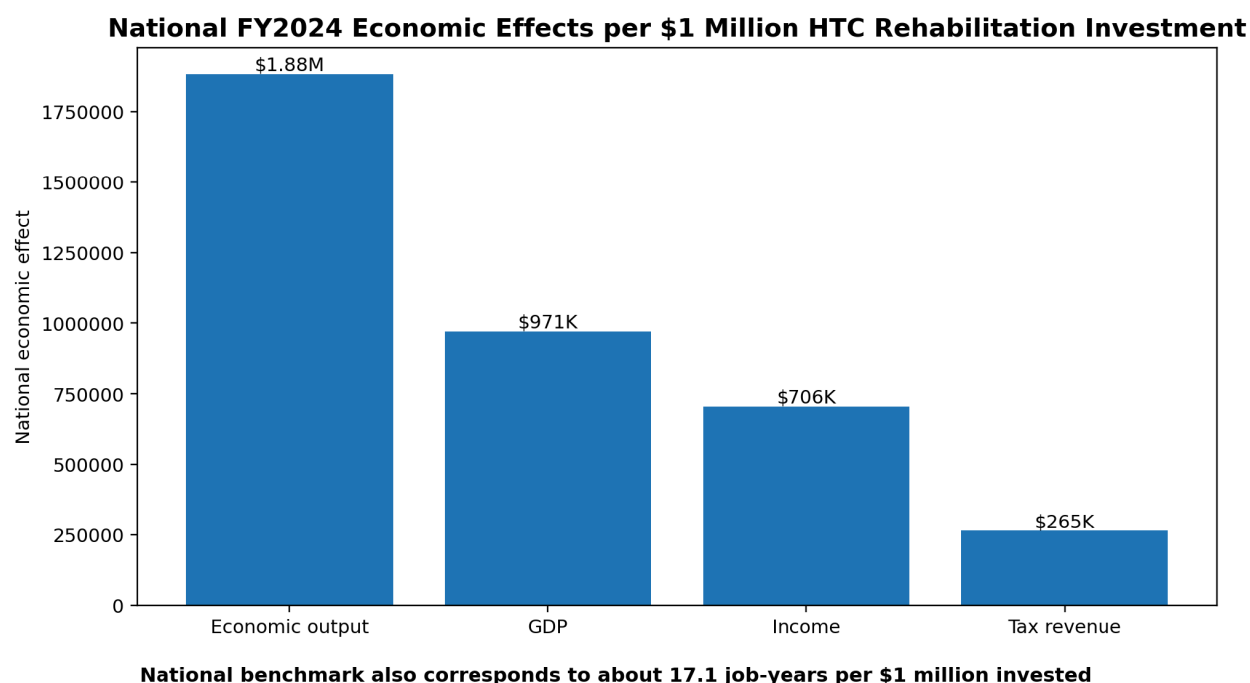


Figure 10. National FY2024 HTC economic impact normalized per \$1 million rehabilitation investment. This is a national benchmark and is not used as a Thurmond-specific multiplier. Source: NPS / Rutgers [11].

The national program data are useful for one narrow reason: they demonstrate that historic rehabilitation is not merely a transfer of money into a static building. Construction activity purchases labor, professional services, materials, and specialized trades before the operating business opens. NPS further reports that 74% of FY2024 HTC projects were in economically distressed areas, 41% were in low- and moderate-income census tracts, and 34% were in communities with populations below 50,000. [11] Rural and distressed-market conditions are therefore common within the national HTC portfolio rather than exceptional to it.

What Economic Success Should Mean for NPS and Thurmond

The demonstration should be judged with a shared scorecard so that federal, municipal, preservation, and business interests are not talking past one another. The goal is not maximum commercial activity at any cost. The goal is productive use that improves the district economy while meeting federal preservation, safety, and resource-protection requirements.

Measure	Why it matters	Pilot measurement
Outside capital leverage	Tests whether federal ownership can attract capital rather than require NPS to fund all work	Non-NPS dollars committed / NPS dollars committed
NPS carrying-burden change	Tests whether leasing meaningfully changes ongoing federal asset cost	DM&R/accounting treatment, assigned maintenance, inspection and operating obligations
Lease revenue	Creates a measurable federal return and maintenance funding source	Annual fair-market rent and rent-adjustment structure
Historic asset preservation	Retains irreplaceable district fabric in productive condition	Standards-compliant rehabilitation and maintenance plan
Visitor dwell time	Measures whether the district experience becomes more valuable	Median time in Thurmond before vs. after activation
Local visitor spending	Measures conversion of existing traffic into commerce	Average spend and total direct sales attributable to visitors
Employment	Measures local operating benefit	Construction job-years and permanent/seasonal jobs
Follow-on investment	Measures catalytic effect	Capital committed to adjacent or subsequent projects
Visitor satisfaction	Tests whether the product addresses the reported experience gap	Survey score and likelihood to recommend/return

Governance and operating roles

The project is most likely to work when each institution performs the function it is best equipped to perform. NPS should retain federal stewardship, property, preservation review, leasing authority, and life-safety requirements. The Town of Thurmond should define community-development priorities and participate in local coordination. SHPO and PAWV can provide preservation standards, financing/program guidance, technical assistance, and capacity development. A selected private or nonprofit operator should carry the operating business and those rehabilitation/maintenance obligations assigned by lease. Banks, CDFIs, and tax-credit investors should underwrite the project on commercial and mission criteria. Kidd's Technical Services' role in this report is limited to economic, spatial, data, and project-development analysis and recommendation; any future role would be separately determined. Ownership and public authority remain where they legally belong.

Recommended Decision Path

Based on the evidence assembled to date, the district has a conditionally favorable economic-development outlook if at least one viable adaptive-reuse transaction can be closed and used as a repeatable model. Kidd's Technical Services recommends a defined transaction-readiness effort with coordinated participation among NPS Commercial Services, park management, the Town of Thurmond, WV SHPO, PAWV, economic-development partners, and prospective financing institutions.

The immediate federal decision is not whether every historic structure must remain indefinitely. The immediate question is whether irreversible demolition should proceed before the new 2026 leasing capacity, existing tax-credit market, active state preservation programs, and property-specific lease potential have been tested together in a time-bounded transaction process. Because the 2025 FONSI is already an authorized decision, any deferral would need to be an affirmative administrative choice by NPS consistent with safety, contracts, funding, and law.

A successful first transaction can convert the debate from "maintenance liability versus demolition" to "which assets can carry outside investment, productive use, and recurring preservation revenue?"

Why this merits immediate review

The economic facts now align in a way they did not when the 2024 EA was written: park visitation has continued to rise; the park visitor economy is measured in tens of millions of dollars annually; the final NPS decision itself recognized a possible Thurmond lease; the park now publishes a current leasing framework; West Virginia provides a 25% historic rehabilitation credit and up to a 35% Tourism Development Act credit for qualifying projects; SHPO has a current bricks-and-mortar grant round; PAWV has active low-cost and human-capacity programs; and West Virginia banks and CDFIs have demonstrated participation in preservation-driven tourism redevelopment. [1]-[3][7]-[18][21]

Taken together, these facts do not guarantee that a particular building can be saved economically. They do establish that an investable pathway exists in law and in precedent and that the pathway has not yet been fully underwritten at the district scale using current 2026 conditions.

Implementation Considerations

The economic case is strongest when its constraints are treated as underwriting questions rather than minimized. The NPS DM&R figures used in this report are facilities-accounting values, not present-day contractor rehabilitation bids. NPS states that DM&R does not include accessibility alterations, upgrades to current building codes, new fire-suppression systems, capacity expansion, or annual recurring maintenance. [9] Several Thurmond review sheets separately identify missing utilities, asbestos-containing materials, structural damage, mold, steep-slope access, vandalism exposure, and other site-specific issues. [4] Actual occupancy rehabilitation costs may therefore exceed - or differ substantially from - the DM&R values shown here.

The condition of individual assets varies sharply. The Erskine Pugh Rental House was described by NPS as in danger of collapse, with very low or no reuse potential without investment far exceeding its value. The Charles Ashley outbuilding and garage and the McGuffin Garage were also assessed as having little or no reuse potential. By contrast, the seven houses analyzed above received medium historic-leasing ratings in 2024. [4] The recommended process should not assume equal treatment of every structure; it should prioritize buildings where condition, access, lease structure, historic significance, customer use, and financing can align.

Tax incentives also require careful transaction design. The federal credit applies to qualified income-producing rehabilitations and NPS property presents lease-structure and tax-exempt-use questions that should be reviewed by experienced historic-tax-credit counsel and accountants. Face-value credits are not the same as immediate construction cash, and investor pricing and transaction costs will reduce or delay some proceeds. The West Virginia Tourism Development Act is a credit against qualifying sales tax generated by an approved project, not an upfront grant. It requires more than \$1 million in approved costs, at least 25% out-of-state visitation, a minimum 100 days of annual operation, additional employment, a positive state economic impact, and project approval before opening; a \$10,000 application fee is currently published. [13] State grant dollars and other state tax credits cannot simply be counted again as Tourism Development Act approved costs on the same expenditure.

Grant resources are competitive and timing-sensitive. The SHPO Development Grant is reimbursement-based and requires a 50/50 match, including non-federal cash. [14] PAWV's microloan is intentionally small relative to major rehabilitation and is best understood as predevelopment/gap capital. Preserve WV AmeriCorps adds capacity rather than construction dollars and has sponsor-eligibility and supervision requirements. [16][17] No grant award, tax-credit investor, bank loan, CDFI loan, or lease is assumed as committed funding in this outlook.

NPS leasing itself is a public process. The current New River Gorge leasing page states that NPS cannot accept unsolicited lease proposals where an RFP is required, and all leases must provide fair-market-value rent determined by appraisal. [8] The demonstration should therefore prepare market evidence and transaction terms that help NPS decide whether to initiate the appropriate public process rather than attempting to bypass it.

Finally, the current physical and administrative status of each structure must be confirmed before the property list is treated as available. The 2025 FONSI authorizes implementation of selected demolitions and states that at least 11 contributing Thurmond structures are to be removed, with the Tom Kelly House also subject to removal if no viable lease proposal is received. [7] This report does not assume that every 2024 candidate remains standing or available in September 2026. The first action in any transaction-readiness effort should be a current NPS status confirmation and field inventory.

What additional evidence will convert this outlook into a lender-grade feasibility study

A bankable model requires current rehabilitation scopes and bids; eligible QRE schedules; asbestos and environmental estimates; utility and access engineering; NPS appraisal and lease terms; customer intercept data; an identified use and operator; sales, staffing, insurance, and maintenance assumptions; and nonbinding or binding financing indications. Those are precisely the outputs the proposed six-month effort is designed to produce. Until then, the dollar figures in the visitor scenarios should be read as market-capacity tests and the incentive figures as statutory financing opportunities, not as guaranteed project proceeds.

Conclusion

Thurmond's economic position is stronger than a vacant-building ledger suggests. The district sits inside a national park that received nearly two million recreation visits in 2025. Its wider 2024 visitor economy produced \$95.5 million in gateway spending and \$110 million in economic output. Thurmond itself recorded 19,233 visitors. At that existing traffic level, every additional \$10 captured per visitor equals \$192,330 in annual direct sales. A local spending level equal to half of the NPS regional benchmark corresponds to about \$507,000 per year and more than \$5 million over ten years even with no visitor growth. [1]-[3]

At the same time, 95.3% of the exact Thurmond DM&R dollars available in ten 2024 structure sheets are concentrated in seven houses that NPS itself rated medium for historic leasing. [4] Federal and state historic tax credits can create a nominal 45% credit layer on qualifying rehabilitation expenditures. West Virginia's Tourism Development Act can provide up to a 35% sales-tax credit on separately eligible approved tourism-development costs, including qualifying utility and communications infrastructure. SHPO and PAWV provide additional preservation funding, low-cost financing, and execution capacity. NPS has statutory authority to adjust rent for lessee preservation expenditures and to use lease receipts for preservation, capital improvement, and maintenance; New River Gorge now has a published leasing framework. [8][10]-[18]

The resulting economic proposition is not that preservation has no cost. It is that the cost can be reorganized. Instead of leaving selected structures as vacant federal liabilities until removal, a long-term lease can be tested as a mechanism for drawing private, nonprofit, bank, CDFI, tax-credit, grant, and operating capital into a federal historic asset. If one transaction works, its value is larger than one rehabilitated building: it creates the local market evidence, administrative pathway, financing relationships, and visitor product needed to lower the risk of subsequent investment across the district.

For that reason, the current evidence supports a time-bounded, property-specific economic reuse demonstration before remaining viable options are irreversibly lost. A six-month transaction-readiness period centered on the Tom Kelly House and any other still-standing candidates that NPS is willing to screen would provide a disciplined way to answer the question with actual costs, actual lease terms, actual visitor data, and actual financing interest. If the numbers fail, the record will show why. If they work, Thurmond and NPS will have established a preservation mechanism capable of reducing federal carrying burden while improving the economic and visitor value of the historic district.

The opportunity is therefore measurable, financeable enough to test, and aligned with both the park's earlier planning history and West Virginia's current economic-development tools. Kidd's Technical Services recommends testing the transaction before concluding that demolition is the only financially rational end state.

Appendix A - Thurmond Structure Economics from the 2024 NPS Review Sheets

Structure	FMSS	2024 DM&R	NPS reuse / leasing assessment	Key condition / economic note
Charles Ashley Outbuilding	87692	\$14,903	Very limited	64 sq ft; prior 2004 roof/paint approx. \$3,000
Charles Ashley Garage	87691	\$72,654	Very limited	Prior 2004 roof/paint \$3,300; additional 2016 work
May Bagoski House	87694	\$355,059	Medium	No utilities; asbestos; unsafe porches; substantial rehab/utility work
Harold Smith House	87696	\$216,913	Medium	No utilities; stabilized in 2006; substantial rehab/utility work
Sidney Allen Ward House	87713	\$242,154	Medium	No utilities; asbestos; prior stabilization work
Wedzel Young House	87698	\$212,831	Medium	No utilities; asbestos; poor porches; prior stabilization work
Marilyn Brown House	99932	Not stated	Interpretive potential	Serious condition; internal bracing; asbestos; old cost records unavailable
Tom Kelly House	87702	\$195,624	Medium	No utilities; asbestos; private-property access issue; FONSI allows possible lease
Erskine Pugh Rental House	87708	Not stated	Very low / none	Danger of collapse; prior stabilization \$30,857; storm damage
James Humphrey Sr. House	97097	\$266,739	Medium	No utilities; asbestos; substantial rehab/utility work
Ice House	87704	\$6,353	Reuse possible	On CSX property with park easement; houses Depot water equipment
McGuffin Garage	87705	Not stated	None	Asbestos identified; no prior stabilization listed
Phillip A. McClung / Meadows	87711	\$417,957	Medium	No utilities; water intrusion, structural rot and mold

Source: National Park Service, Proposed Demolition of Historic Structures Environmental Assessment, Appendix B, Structure Review Sheets, June 10, 2024. [4] Exact DM&R was not stated on the Marilyn Brown, Erskine Pugh, or McGuffin sheets. The quantified total used in this report therefore includes ten items only.

Quantified totals used in this report

Metric	Amount
Known exact DM&R across ten costed Thurmond sheets	\$2,001,187
DM&R across seven houses rated medium for historic leasing	\$1,907,277
Share of known exact DM&R in those seven houses	95.3%
Other quantified Thurmond DM&R in the ten costed sheets	\$93,910

Appendix B - Funding and Finance Matrix

Tool	Verified value / structure	Core eligibility	Role in a Thurmond transaction	Status used in outlook
Federal Historic Rehabilitation Tax Credit	20% of QRE	Income-producing certified historic rehabilitation	Potential tax-equity/economic value; project-specific tax structure required	Current federal program
WV Historic Rehabilitated Buildings Investment Credit	25% of qualified expenditures	WV certified historic rehab; state/NPS review	May be transferred, sold, or assigned after approval	Current state program
WV Tourism Development Act	25% standard; up to 35% enhanced	Approved tourism project; >\$1M costs; 25% out-of-state; 100 days; jobs; positive impact	Sales-tax credit after project opens; can include qualifying utilities/communications	Current; pre-approval required
WV SHPO State Development Grant	50/50 matching grant	National Register property / contributing resource; eligible applicant/lease	Brick-and-mortar preservation, code/accessibility, appropriate-use work	FY27 deadline Sept. 30, 2026
PAWV Historic Preservation MicroLoan	Up to \$20,000 at 2%	Eligible historic property/applicant	Architecture, engineering, appraisal, tax-credit consulting, stabilization/rehab	Rolling
Preserve WV AmeriCorps	1,700 or 900 service hours	Eligible under-resourced site sponsor and qualifying historic property/program	Capacity, documentation, tourism programming, plans, volunteer management	2026-27 sponsor applications rolling
PAWV Saving Historic Places / Paul Bruhn subgrant pipeline	Varies by round	Round-specific property age/use/match rules	Potential future capital; no current award assumed	Monitor future rounds
Bank / CDFI / HTC investor capital	Project-specific	Underwritten project, lease, operator and sources/uses	Debt/equity to close remaining financing gap	Demonstrated in WV precedent; no commitment assumed
NPS commercial lease	Fair-market rent; lease-specific	NPS leasing authority/RFP and appraisal	Can shift maintenance/capital obligations and generate NPS revenue	Current NERI leasing framework published

This matrix deliberately distinguishes verified statutory/program features from committed financing. No source in this table is treated as awarded or guaranteed to a Thurmond project.

Appendix C - Scenario Methodology

This report uses a simple transparent scenario model rather than a proprietary economic-impact model. The objective is to show what existing visitor traffic could support under different levels of local spending capture without manufacturing a precise forecast from incomplete local operating data.

Input	Value	Source / treatment
2024 Thurmond visitors	19,233	Fayette County 2024 tourism report [2]
2024 New River Gorge recreation visits	1,811,937	NPS IRMA [1]
2025 New River Gorge recreation visits	1,958,440	NPS IRMA [1]
2024 NPS gateway visitor spending	\$95.5 million	NPS Visitor Spending Effects [3]
Gateway-spending benchmark	\$52.71 / park visit	\$95.5M divided by 1,811,937; regional scale benchmark only
Local capture scenarios	25%, 50%, 75%	Planning sensitivities; not observed Thurmond shares
Visitor growth sensitivity	0% and 2% annually	Scenario assumption; 0% is the no-growth reference
DM&R, seven medium-leasing houses	\$1,907,277	Exact 2024 NPS sheet values [4]
Known quantified Thurmond DM&R	\$2,001,187	Ten exact 2024 NPS sheet values [4]

Direct visitor-spending scenarios are calculated as: Thurmond visitors x NPS gateway-spending benchmark x local capture assumption. Ten-year values sum the annual amount over ten years with either zero visitor growth or 2% annual visitor growth. The scenarios do not include multiplier effects, lodging induced by new development, new visitation caused by an improved destination, lease revenue, construction spending, or follow-on investment. As a result, they are intentionally narrower than a full regional input-output analysis.

The national FY2024 Historic Tax Credit economic-impact data are shown separately as a national program benchmark and are not multiplied against Thurmond project costs. A local multiplier should be developed only after a defined rehabilitation budget and construction sourcing plan exist.

Sources and Documentary Basis

- [1] National Park Service IRMA, Annual Park Recreation Visitation - New River Gorge National Park & Preserve (through 2025). [Source link](#)
- [2] Fayette County Convention and Visitors Bureau, Tourism in Fayette County, 2024 annual report submitted to the West Virginia Legislature. [Source link](#)
- [3] National Park Service, 2024 Visitor Spending Effects - New River Gorge National Park & Preserve. [Source link](#)
- [4] National Park Service, Proposed Demolition of Historic Structures Environmental Assessment, PEPC 111561, October 2024; Appendix B Structure Review Sheets (uploaded documentary record).
- [5] National Park Service, Remove Excess Structures, New River Gorge National Park and Preserve, Pre-NEPA Overview Document, December 2023 (uploaded documentary record).
- [6] National Park Service, Record of Decision, General Management Plan and Environmental Impact Statement, New River Gorge National River, approved December 7, 2011 (uploaded signed ROD).
- [7] National Park Service, Finding of No Significant Impact / final decision for Proposed Demolition of Historic Structures, July 2025. [Source link](#)
- [8] National Park Service, Leasing Opportunities in the Park - New River Gorge National Park & Preserve, updated August 31, 2026. [Source link](#)
- [9] National Park Service, New River Gorge National Park and Preserve Deferred Maintenance and Repairs Factsheet, FY2025. [Source link](#)
- [10] 54 U.S.C. Section 102102, National Park Service leasing authority, rent adjustments and use of lease proceeds. [Source link](#)
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- [12] West Virginia Tax Division, TSD-110, Historic Rehabilitated Buildings Investment Credit. [Source link](#)
- [13] West Virginia Tourism Development Act, W. Va. Code Chapter 5B, Article 2E; West Virginia Division of Economic Development program guidance. [Source link](#)
- [14] West Virginia State Historic Preservation Office, State Development Grant, FY27. [Source link](#)
- [15] West Virginia State Historic Preservation Office, Survey & Planning Grants. [Source link](#)
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- [19] National Park Service, Leasing Success Stories - Bathhouse Row and Cavallo Point. [Source link](#)
- [20] National Park Service, Case Study: Hale Bathhouse, Hot Springs, Arkansas. [Source link](#)
- [21] Woodlands Development & Lending / Appalachian Community Capital, Tygart Hotel financing and community-bank Historic Tax Credit investment. [Source link](#)
- [22] Appalachian Community Capital, 2025 Opportunity Appalachia Impact Report - Tygart Hotel follow-on investment and jobs. [Source link](#)

Author note

Prepared by Carrie Kidd, Kidd's Technical Services. This report is intended to support a fact-based community, preservation, economic-development, and federal asset-management discussion. It is not a legal opinion, tax opinion, engineering report, appraisal, lease offer, or commitment of financing.



IN-KIND PROFESSIONAL SERVICES CONTRIBUTION RECORD

Kidd's Technical Services

No amount due - professional services donated without charge

Record No.	KTS-THUR-2026-0910-IK
Date of record	September 10, 2026
Provider	Kidd's Technical Services
Professional	Carrie Kidd
Benefiting effort	Thurmond Historic District preservation and economic-development analysis
Related report	Thurmond Historic District Economic Outlook and Preservation Investment Case

Professional services contributed

Independent economic-geography and visitor-economy analysis; review and synthesis of National Park Service planning, leasing, deferred-maintenance, and preservation records; preservation-finance, grant, and tax-incentive research; scenario modeling; data visualization; report writing, editing, and production.

Professional time reported	Approximately 14.0 hours
KTS professional rate	\$300.00 per hour
Estimated professional value	\$4,200.00
Amount donated / waived	\$4,200.00
AMOUNT DUE	\$0.00

Purpose and funding-use note

This record documents professional services voluntarily contributed by Kidd's Technical Services to the Thurmond historic-preservation and economic-development effort. It is not a bill, does not create a payment obligation, and is not represented as an automatically eligible grant match. A future grant recipient may use this record as supporting documentation of contributed professional services only when the applicable program permits the contribution, the recipient accepts and records it, the services and valuation are allowable and reasonable, and all timing and documentation requirements are satisfied. The same contribution must not be counted toward more than one award.

Important current-program example: the West Virginia SHPO FY27 State Development Grant allows in-kind match, but requires grant and match resources to be expended for services completed during the approved project period. Because this report work predates any such grant agreement, it should not be represented as FY27 Development Grant match unless SHPO provides written approval.

Certification

I certify that this record reflects my good-faith account of the professional services contributed without charge and the valuation shown above, based on the stated Kidd's Technical Services professional rate and approximately 14 hours of professional time.

Carrie A Kidd
Carrie Kidd, Owner - Kidd's Technical Services

9/10/2027
Date

Supporting documentation recommended for any future funding use: KTS rate documentation, a dated time record, a copy of the report, and written acknowledgment by the receiving applicant or fiscal agent.